

From download to your first invoice in 15 minutes.

You have two files: **Freelance-Invoice-Tracker.xlsx** — the workbook — and this guide. Everything below takes less time than making coffee.

What this file does

- Writes a **print-ready invoice** from your line items — pick a number, press Ctrl/Cmd+P, save as PDF.
- Keeps your **invoice numbers straight**: it suggests the next free one and flags duplicates on the spot.
- Shows you every morning **who is late and by how many days**, and what the next reminder step is.
- Adds up **what is outstanding, what is overdue and what actually got paid** — in any currency you type.

What it does not do

- It does **not send emails** — it writes the text, you paste it into your mail programme.
- It does **not connect to your bank**. You enter payments yourself.
- It has **no tax rules, no rates and no country logic**, and gives no tax, legal or accounting advice.
- It contains **no macros** and needs no add-on, no account and no internet connection.

THE SIX SHEETS, IN THE ORDER YOU WILL USE THEM

SHEET	WHAT IT IS FOR
1 • Start Here	Your details, currency, invoice-number prefix, payment terms and the three reminder thresholds. Eighteen yellow boxes — everything else in the file reads from them.
2 • Dashboard	Outstanding, overdue now, oldest overdue, paid in the last 30 days, average days to pay, invoiced this month, the ageing band and who to chase today. Nothing to type.
3 • Invoices	One row per invoice, 250 rows ready. Due date, totals, open amount, status, days overdue and the next reminder step calculate themselves.
4 • Line Items	One row per item, 500 rows ready, tagged with its invoice number from a dropdown. Qty × unit price – discount lands back on the Invoices sheet.
5 • Invoice (print)	The finished document. Pick a number in cell C1 and the whole page fills — up to 12 line slots, totals, payment block, status stamp. The reminder email sits underneath, outside the print area.
6 • Lists	The four dropdown lists: stage, unit, currency, payment terms. Empty rows are yours to fill.

BEFORE YOU START

Opening the file

Excel: double-click `Freelance-Invoice-Tracker.xlsx`. If a yellow “Protected View” bar appears, click **Enable Editing** — that bar shows for every downloaded file, there is nothing to unblock beyond it.

Google Sheets: see page 3 — it is a four-click import and nothing is lost on the way.

LibreOffice Calc opens the file out of the box. **Apple Numbers** works too; minor visual differences are possible.

The file arrives as a working demo, not an empty shell. Eight example invoices and twenty line items are already in there so you can see every state at work — paid, part-paid, open, draft and three degrees of overdue. Their dates are written as `=TODAY()-n`, so the demo never looks stale. Step 3 on the next page removes it in two clicks.

Your first fifteen minutes, step by step.

Do these six steps in order. At the end of them you will have a real invoice as a PDF and a dashboard that watches it for you.

1 MINUTE 0–3 · START HERE

Fill the eighteen yellow boxes

Business name, your name, address, country, email, phone or website. Then the ones that drive the rest of the file: **currency symbol or code** (pick from the dropdown or simply type your own — AED, HUF, anything), **invoice number prefix** (e.g. 2026–), **default payment terms in days**, the **three reminder thresholds** (7, 21 and 45 days out of the box) and the two **payment detail lines** that print on every invoice. The tax or registration number box ships empty on purpose — put in whatever your country calls it, or leave it blank.

2 MINUTE 3–5 · INVOICES AND LINE ITEMS

Look at the demo before you delete it

Open **Invoices** and read rows 8 to 15 from left to right. Watch what the grey columns did: due dates worked out from the terms, a status per row, days overdue counted, and an action — *First reminder*, *Second reminder*, *Last friendly reminder* — chosen from your own thresholds. Then open **Dashboard** and see the same eight rows turned into money.

3 MINUTE 5–6 · THE ONLY DESTRUCTIVE STEP

Clear the demo — the safe way

Select **Invoices rows 8–15** → right-click → **Delete rows**. Then **Line Items rows 8–27** → right-click → **Delete rows**. You lose 8 of 250 invoice rows and 20 of 500 item rows, nothing else — Excel and Google Sheets pull every range up behind you.

Do not use “Clear contents” on a whole row. That would wipe the grey formulas along with the demo text and leave you with a gap in the sheet. Deleting the row is the safe move. And do not type over the demo rows either — their dates are live `=TODAY()-n` formulas, and you would carry a moving date into a real invoice.

4 MINUTE 6–10 · INVOICES, ROW 8

Enter your first invoice

Invoice no. — the Dashboard and Start Here both show you the **next free number**, so just type it. Then the invoice date, the client, the client email, the client address and the project reference. Leave **Terms** empty to use your default from Start Here, or pick another from the dropdown. Type the client address only once per client: a later invoice for the same client reuses it on the printable page. A multi-line address: **Alt+Enter** on Windows, **Ctrl+Option+Enter** on a Mac.

5 MINUTE 10–13 · LINE ITEMS

List what you are billing for

One row per item. Pick the **invoice number from the dropdown**, write the description, then quantity or hours, the unit (hour, day, item, project, page, word, month, km, licence ...), the unit price and — if you want — a discount in per cent. The amount calculates itself, and the net total lands back on the Invoices sheet without you doing anything.

6 MINUTE 13–15 · INVOICE (PRINT)

Print it, send it

Type or pick your invoice number in **cell C1** — the only cell you ever touch on that sheet. Sender block, client block, dates, line items, totals and the payment block fill in by themselves. **Ctrl/Cmd+P** → **Save as PDF**. Row 1 with the picker stays off the printout. Scroll down past the document and you will find the reminder email, already written, for the day it becomes necessary.

Google Sheets, grey cells, and the small print.

GOOGLE SHEETS — FREE, AND NOTHING IS LOST

- Go to `sheets.google.com` and open a blank spreadsheet.
- Menu **File** → **Import** → **Upload**, choose `Freelance-Invoice-Tracker.xlsx`.
- Pick “**Replace spreadsheet**” and confirm. Formulas, dropdowns, number formats and colours all survive the trip.
- Rename the file and you are done. No Microsoft licence needed anywhere in this.
- **Printing from Sheets:** on **Invoice (print)** select `A2:G45` → **File** → **Print** → **Selected cells** → **Fit to width**. That is the same area Excel prints.

YELLOW = YOU TYPE. GREY = IT CALCULATES ITSELF.

Never type in a grey cell: you would overwrite a formula and the sheet would quietly stop being right. If you do it by accident, press Ctrl/Cmd+Z straight away.

SHEET	THESE CELLS CALCULATE THEMSELVES
Dashboard	All of it. There is no input cell on this sheet at all.
Invoices	Due date · Net amount · Tax amount · Total · Open amount · Status · Days overdue · Action · Check
Line Items	Amount · Link check
Invoice (print)	Everything except cell C1, where you pick the invoice number.
Start Here	“Next free invoice number” — the rest of the sheet is yours to fill.

GOOD TO KNOW

Invoice numbers

The file suggests the next free number and flags a duplicate the moment it appears — but it cannot stop you typing one twice. If you already have invoices from before, type your highest existing number into the first row once; the suggestion counts up from the highest number in the sheet. **Do not use * or ? inside an invoice number** — both are wildcard characters and would quietly make the totals wrong. The check column warns you if one slips in.

The reminder ladder

Three numbers on Start Here decide when the Action column changes its mind: first reminder, second reminder, last friendly reminder — 7, 21 and 45 days past the due date out of the box. Change them to anything you like; the only rule is first < second < last, and the sheet tells you if you break it. Before the due date the same column says *Due soon* and *Due today*, so red always means act now, never history.

Currency and the rate column

One cell on Start Here holds your currency — a symbol or a code, whatever you type. Every money heading in the file picks it up. The rate column works the same way: the file has **no rates of its own**. It multiplies the percentage you type in the Tax rate column (or the default you set on Start Here, which ships at 0) and adds it up. Leave it at 0 if that is right for you.

Capacity, and what happens at the edges

250 invoices, 500 line items. Twelve line items print on one invoice; if an invoice has more, the printable sheet says so in plain words instead of silently cutting them off — shorten the lines or split the invoice. Part payments are fine: enter what came in and the status becomes *Part-paid* with the rest still counted as open.

Three habits, and the honest limits.

THREE HABITS THAT MAKE IT WORK

1 Every invoice goes into the register the day you send it

Not at the end of the month. The row takes twenty seconds and from that moment the file is watching the due date for you.

2 Enter the payment the day it lands

Paid amount and paid date, two cells. The status flips to *Paid* by itself, the countdown goes quiet, the invoice leaves the chase list, and your average days-to-pay gets one more honest data point.

3 Five minutes on the Dashboard every Monday

Work down “Who to chase today” from the top. For each row: open **Invoice (print)**, put that number in C1, copy the reminder email that appears underneath, send it, then note the date in the “Follow-up sent on” column so you know when you last nudged.

WHAT THIS FILE IS NOT

No tax, legal or accounting advice. This workbook contains no tax rules, no rates and no country logic. It multiplies the percentage you type in and adds it up — that is the whole of its arithmetic on that front.

Whatever your country requires to appear on an invoice — a registration number, a tax line, a small-business note, a payment-terms clause — belongs in the two free-text boxes on Start Here: the **tax or registration number** and the **footer note printed on every invoice**. Both are yours to write.

The reminder email below the printable invoice is **template wording, not a formal legal demand**. If you need to escalate, check what a formal demand has to look like where you are.

LICENCE

One buyer, one business. Use this workbook for your own invoicing, on as many devices as you like, including commercially. Please do not resell it, redistribute it, share it as a file, or include it in a product of your own. Thank you — small shops live on that courtesy.

SUPPORT

Questions, or a formula behaving oddly? Message us on Etsy — we answer every message within 48 hours. Tell us which sheet, which cell and what you expected to see; that is usually enough to sort it out in one reply. If something in the file turns out to be genuinely broken we will correct it and reupload, and you can download the newer version from your Etsy purchases at no extra cost.

ONE-LINE REMINDERS

Yellow = you type

Grey = it calculates

Delete demo rows, never clear them

No * or ? in invoice numbers

250 invoices · 500 line items

12 lines print per invoice

Currency = one cell

Ctrl/Cmd+P → PDF

No macros, works offline